▼ VIEWPOINT

AI AS OUR COGNITIVE PARTNER

BY JAYANT SINHA

India will profit from partnering with AI to simulate futures, shape systems and solve complex challenges

Today, most AI (artificial intelligence) users turn to these apps to summarise documents, answer technical questions or draft content. In contrast, a select group treats AI as a cognitive partner—using it to model complex systems, plan strategic scenarios and integrate insights across finance, governance, climate and technology.

This shift is far from cosmetic. Strategic users force AI models to engage at deeper levels: holding longer context windows, managing memory layers and performing multi-step reasoning across domains. As a result, these interactions are significantly heavier on computational resources—sometimes 5-10 times costlier than average usage—but they also stretch AI's capabilities in ways that pure engineering improvements cannot.

Such strategic AI usage could dramatically accelerate solutions to India's most pressing challenges: modelling healthcare access gaps in rural areas, optimising urban infrastructure investments for future demands, personalising education pathways for millions of students and simulating the risks and opportunities of climate adaptation. In energy, AI could model regional renewable supply-demand balances, optimise grid investments and forecast adoption curves for emerging technologies like green hydrogen and electric mobility.

Illustration by RAJ VERMA

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But first, AI literacy must evolve. Leaders in government, business and civil society need to move beyond basic familiarity with AI tools. They must learn how to use AI for systems thinking, scenario planning and strategic design. In the 21st century, AI competence will be as fundamental for leadership as financial literacy or policy analysis.

Second, institutions must invest in AI-augmented strategy teams. These teams should not focus on routine automation, but on deeper tasks: simulating policy trade-offs, analysing complex system dynamics and integrating multi-sectoral data for better decision-making.

Third, we must move past the idea of AI as just another tool. AI has the potential to expand human cognitive reach. Strategic engagement with AI is not about abdicating human judgement; it's about enhancing it. AI can generate possibilities, surface patterns and simulate outcomes. But humans must frame priorities, weigh trade-offs and define values.

To build this capacity, India must also rethink how it trains its top talent. Now, we must train leaders to think across disciplines, model complex systems and collaborate deeply with AI systems. Integrating AI-driven strategic thinking into elite education programmes, civil service training, corporate leadership pipelines and policy-making institutions will be critical.

At a global level, the divide between casual and strategic users will widen. Early adopters who master AI as a cognitive partner will think faster, move smarter and build stronger institutions. Others will be left playing catch-up. Ultimately, the frontier of AI will not be shaped only by engineers writing better code. It will be shaped by how creatively and strategically humans partner with AI systems.

India, with its reservoir of talent and scale of ambition, has the chance to lead this shift. But it must invest deliberately—in building strategic AI capacity across education, institutions and leadership mindsets. The AI era will be defined not just by technological advances, but by cognitive collaboration. Those who learn to think and build with AI will define the next phase of global innovation and governance. ■

Jayant Sinha is a Distinguished Fellow at ORF and Visiting Professor at the LSE. He is a former Union minister. Views are personal